TIME TO DETOX

With the young, adolescents and even the elderly becoming prisoners of their various devices–whether phone, tablet or the computer screen–and battling isolation, anxiety and insomnia, experts outline how you can break free

By SONALI ACHARJEE / *Illustrations by* NILANJAN DAS

EVERY MORNING, 12-YEAR-OLD AMRITA (*name changed*), lets her 592 friends on Facebook know what she did the day before. And there is plenty for this Delhi schoolgirl to post. "I wake up at 4.30 am and study till 8 am," she says. Breaks between online classes are spent doing quick high-intensity workouts. Post school, there are guitar tutorials online, and homework to finish. Recently, Amrita surprised her mother by cooking her own dinner, but it was only so she could post pictures online.

She says she derives her energy from the number of 'likes' and 'wows' she gets on FB. Any negative comment, however, and she breaks down in tears. Sometimes, she is on her phone all night, mindlessly scrolling on FB. "I feel peaceful, it calms me down," she says. But the price she pays for it? Insomnia, for which she is currently visiting the Behavioural Addiction Clinic at AIIMS in Delhi, the institute's psychiatric OPD for internet, phone, gaming and social media addiction.

With Covid-19 occupying all our attention, we have been oblivious to another pandemic creeping up silently on us—the scourge of digital dependency. It holds young children and even toddlers in thrall, afflicts adolescents and adults alike. Once a leisure activity, it slowly overtook our lives. The advent of social media made things worse. It opened up the world, but also ended up making us insular. Likewise, the increasing digital penetration in the country was a laudable thing, but it also helped the malaise spread wider. Then came 2020 and the pandemic when the digital device became both a boon and a curse, a cure for loneliness, and also its cause. It was only a matter of time before the toll began to tell: in declining attention spans, behavioural changes, anxiety, insomnia, depression, physical pain, even violence. Waking up to the peril, schools and hospitals have started providing counselling and deaddiction facilities, and people are flocking to seek treatment, either at a rehab facility or through self-regulation. But, first, the nature of the beast.